

THE AEO PLAYBOOK

2026 EDITION

The Complete System to Get Your Business
Cited in ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity and
other AI search engines

(whether you sell products, services or
software)

THE AEO PLAYBOOK

2026 Edition

Version 1.0, Published June 2026

The methodology in this playbook is current as of 2026.

AI search is evolving fast. Buyers receive all future updates free,
including new engines, new tactics, and new case studies
as I run them.

Built for founders and operators, by a founder.

Read this first.

Here's what you need to know before you start.

I'm a founder.

I got tired of building products, building services, building brands, and then watching customers ask ChatGPT for recommendations and not hearing my name come up. Not once. Not in any of the obvious queries. Not in any of the comparison queries. Nothing.

So I did what most founders do. I went looking for answers.

I spent thousands of dollars on courses. AEO courses, GEO courses, "AI SEO" courses, \$497 cohorts, \$1,200 masterminds, \$50 ebooks. I bought them all. I read them all.

Most of them said the same five things, dressed up in different language. None of them showed the actual work. None of them gave me a system I could run on Monday morning. Most of them were repackaged SEO advice with the word "AI" pasted on top.

So I stopped buying courses and started running experiments.

I ran audits across ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity, and Google AI Overviews on dozens of businesses. Product brands. SaaS companies. Agencies. Local services. B2B platforms. I watched what worked across every category. I tracked what moved share of voice and what didn't. I built systems. The prompts, the spreadsheets, the outreach templates, the schema, the comparison page structures. I tested it on my own business and on others.

This playbook is the result.

It's everything I wish someone had handed me when I first realized AI search was eating my future revenue. No fluff. No theory. No filler chapters about "the history of AI." Just the system that actually works in 2026, the exact templates I use, and the 90-day plan to put it in motion.

A few things you should know before you read on.

This works for any business. Whether you sell physical products, software, services, or expertise, the core mechanics are the same. AI engines decide who gets cited based on signals that apply across every industry. The examples in this playbook span DTC brands, SaaS companies, agencies, local services, and B2B platforms, so you can find the pattern that matches your business.

This is built for new and unknown businesses, not just established ones. Most AEO content assumes you have a Wikipedia page, press hits, and a 5-year-old domain. Most businesses don't. This playbook was written specifically for the founder or operator whose business is brand-new, has no authority, no PR, no Reddit history, and still wants to get cited.

AEO is not a replacement for SEO. It's the layer on top. Anyone telling you to "abandon SEO and focus on AEO" is selling you something. The truth is messier. You need both, and the smart operators are building both in parallel right now.

This is slow. Faster than SEO, but not instant. If you execute the 90-day plan, you'll see share-of-voice movement by week 8-12. If you're looking for an overnight hack, this isn't it.

Everything here is what I do for paying clients. I run AEO consulting as my day job. I charge thousands per month to do this work for businesses across multiple industries. The playbook is the same system, formatted for you to run yourself. If at the end you decide you'd rather have someone do it for you, there's a link at the back to book a call.

Last thing.

The "2026 Edition" on the cover isn't marketing. It's a commitment.

AI search is changing fast. Google's May 2026 update deprecated FAQ rich results overnight. ChatGPT, Claude, and Perplexity push new models and citation behaviors every few months. Half the AEO advice published in 2024 is already wrong. Most of what you'll find on YouTube from 2023 is dangerously outdated.

This playbook reflects the landscape as of 2026, including the May update and what it actually means for AI citation (most people are getting it wrong, covered in Lever 5).

Every buyer gets all future updates free. As Google and AI engines shift, the playbook shifts with them. If you bought v1.0 today, you'll still have the latest version a year from now.

Let's get into it.

HOW TO USE THIS PLAYBOOK

There are six parts.

Part 1 sets up the landscape. Read it once, in order. Don't skip. The framing matters.

Part 2 is the audit. Run it on your own business before reading further. Knowing where you stand makes the rest of the book ten times more useful.

Part 3 is the system. The seven levers that actually move the needle. Read it once cover to cover, then come back to specific levers as you execute.

Part 4 is the 90-day plan. Print it. Tape it to your wall. Cross things off.

Part 5 is the list of mistakes I've seen kill momentum. Read before you start, and again at week 4.

Part 6 is the honest conversation about whether to do this yourself or hire it out.

The templates referenced throughout are all in the back, in the Appendix.

If you've got 30 minutes, read Part 1 and the start of Part 2 today. That alone will shift how you think about search. The rest can wait until tomorrow.

Let's go.

PART 1: THE NEW REALITY

Chapter 1: Search is moving, and most businesses are asleep

Here's a question. When was the last time you Googled something?

Now ask yourself a second question. When was the last time you asked ChatGPT, Claude, or Perplexity something instead of Googling it?

If you're honest, the second answer is closer in time than the first.

You're not alone. As of 2026, ChatGPT processes over a billion queries a day. Perplexity has grown into one of the fastest-growing search products of the last decade. Claude is embedded into how millions of professionals do research. Google itself, the company that defined search for 20 years, now shows an AI-generated answer at the top of nearly every meaningful query.

Search didn't die. It moved.

And most businesses haven't noticed.

The shift in three sentences

For 20 years, the game was: rank high on Google so people click your link.

Today, the game is: get cited by AI so people hear your name in the answer.

The difference is everything.

When someone Googled "best running shoes for marathons" in 2015, they saw ten blue links. They clicked through, evaluated options, and made a decision. Your brand could be on page 1, page 2, or page 5, and at least you existed. You had a shot.

When someone asks ChatGPT "what are the best running shoes for marathons" in 2026, ChatGPT names three to five brands in its answer. That's it. There is no page 2. There is no "ten blue links." There is one answer, with a small number of brands inside it. The rest don't exist.

If you're not one of the named brands, the customer never knows you exist.

Why this matters more than people realize

Most operators look at this and shrug. "AI search is still small. Google is still the default. I'll deal with it later."

That instinct is wrong, for two reasons.

First, AI search isn't replacing Google all at once. It's eating specific use cases. Comparison shopping. Recommendation requests. "What should I buy" questions. "What's the best tool for" questions. "Which company does X" questions.

These are not random queries. These are the highest-intent purchase decisions your customer makes. The moment they're deciding between you and a competitor, or trying to figure out which company solves their problem, is the moment they're increasingly asking AI instead of Google.

AI search is taking the most valuable part of search first.

Second, citation patterns compound. The brands that get cited in AI answers today become the brands AI defaults to citing tomorrow. Every time GPT-4 or Claude or Perplexity mentions a competitor without mentioning you, that competitor's position in the AI's "this is who matters in this category" map gets reinforced. Yours doesn't.

This is the same dynamic that turned early SEO winners into permanent winners. The brands that figured out SEO in 2005-2010 are still ranking on Google in 2026. The brands that figure out AEO in 2025-2027 will be cited in AI answers for the next decade.

The window is open right now. Most of your competitors don't know it exists.

What this isn't

Before we go further, let me kill three myths.

Myth 1: "AI search is a fad." It's not. Every major tech company has bet hundreds of billions of dollars on AI being the new interface for information. Google, Microsoft, Meta, Apple, Anthropic, OpenAI. Whatever your opinion of AI itself, the user behavior shift is happening, and it's not reversing.

Myth 2: "If I rank on Google, I'll rank in AI." Partially true, mostly false. There's overlap, but AI engines weight different signals than Google. A brand can rank #1 on Google for "best CRM for small business" and still not get cited when ChatGPT is asked the same question. The reverse is also true. AEO is its own discipline.

Myth 3: "This only matters for tech and ecommerce." Wrong. AI search is being used to find lawyers, accountants, contractors, consultants, doctors, restaurants, SaaS tools, courses, agencies, and freelancers. If anyone could possibly ask AI "who should I hire for X" or "what should I buy for Y," your business is affected.

The two questions every operator needs to ask

Stop reading for a second. Open ChatGPT in another tab. Type in the single most important question your customer would ask before considering buying from you.

Examples:

- A men's apparel brand: "best men's everyday t-shirt"
- A B2B SaaS company: "best CRM for a 10-person agency"
- A local plumber: "best plumber in [your city]"
- A marketing agency: "best agencies for ecommerce growth"
- A course creator: "best course to learn cold email"

Now look at the answer. Are you mentioned? Are your competitors? Which ones?

This is the first question.

The second question is the harder one. **Why?**

Why does ChatGPT know about that competitor and not about you? Why does it cite that website and not yours? Why is one brand the default answer in your category and another brand invisible?

The answer to that second question is the entire rest of this playbook.

What you'll have when you finish this book

By the end of Part 2, you'll have run the audit on your own business. You'll know your share of voice across all four major AI engines. You'll know which competitors are winning and roughly why.

By the end of Part 3, you'll understand the seven specific levers that move share of voice. You'll have templates for each one.

By the end of Part 4, you'll have a 90-day plan with weekly tasks.

By the end of the book, you'll know more about AEO than 95% of agencies currently selling it as a service.

The brands that move now win the next decade of search.

Let's get to work.

Chapter 2: How AI engines actually decide what to cite

You can't optimize for something you don't understand. Before we run the audit, you need to know how the four major AI engines actually pick which brands to mention.

The short version: they don't all work the same way.

The four engines, simplified

ChatGPT answers using a mix of two things. Its training data, which is everything it learned during model training (frozen at a specific date), and live web browsing, which it uses for newer or time-sensitive queries. Citation behavior depends on which mode it's in. Trained-data answers rarely cite sources. Browse-mode answers do.

Claude works similarly. Training data plus web search when needed. When Claude pulls from the web, it cites. When it answers from training, it usually doesn't.

Perplexity is different. It's citation-first by design. Almost every answer is built from live web sources and shows the sources directly. This makes Perplexity the easiest of the four to influence because the signal is transparent. If you know which sources Perplexity is pulling from, you know where to get yourself mentioned.

Google AI Overviews is the AI answer that appears at the top of regular Google search results. It pulls from top-ranking pages and Google's existing entity database. Strong SEO helps you here more than on the other three. This is the closest cousin to traditional search.

The common signals all four look for

Despite the differences, all four engines weight a few of the same things heavily.

Authority. Where else on the internet does your name appear, and how trustworthy are those sources. A mention on Wirecutter is worth more than a mention on a random blog. A Wikipedia page is worth more than a Twitter post.

Structured content. Pages that directly answer questions in clear language with proper formatting (headers, lists, schema markup) are easier for AI to parse and use as a source.

Entity clarity. Does the AI understand what your business is, what you sell, and who you serve. If your description is inconsistent across the web, AI gets confused and skips you.

Frequency of mention. How often does your brand name appear across the sources AI trusts. Not just on your own site, but on third-party sites, forums, reviews, and roundups.

Recency. Newer content gets weighted higher for time-sensitive queries. A 2024 "best of" list ranks below a 2026 one.

That's the core. Five signals, four engines, one shared logic underneath.

What this means in practice

If you want to be cited, you need to be present where the AI looks (third-party authority sites, forums, structured content) and you need to be clear about what you are (consistent entity definition across the web).

That's it. That's the whole framework underneath everything in Part 3.

The rest of this playbook is the specific tactics that put those signals in motion.

Chapter 3: AEO vs SEO, the honest distinction

There's a popular line going around right now. "SEO is dead. AEO is the future."

It's wrong, and the people selling it know it's wrong.

Here's the honest version.

What SEO gets you

SEO gets you ranked on Google's traditional search results. The blue links. When someone types a query and scrolls past the AI Overview, SEO is what determines whether they see your site.

That traffic still exists. It's smaller than it used to be, and shrinking, but it's not zero. For a lot of queries, especially navigational ones ("[brand name] login," "[brand name] contact"), traditional search is still where everything happens.

What AEO gets you

AEO gets you cited inside AI-generated answers. ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity, Google AI Overviews. This is the layer that's growing fast and where the highest-intent commercial queries are migrating.

Where they overlap

The signals overlap more than you'd expect. Good SEO content (clear, well-structured, authoritative) is also good AEO content. A page that ranks well on Google has a better-than-average chance of being cited by AI. Backlinks from trusted sites help both. Schema markup helps both.

If you're doing SEO well, you're already part way to doing AEO well.

Where they diverge

But only partway. AEO weighs some things SEO doesn't care about.

Reddit and forum mentions matter way more for AEO than for SEO. AI engines pull heavily from community discussions. Google's traditional ranking algorithm mostly ignores them.

Comparison content (Brand X vs Brand Y) is a much bigger lever for AEO. Google ranks comparison pages occasionally. AI cites them constantly.

Entity consistency across the web matters more for AEO. Google can ignore minor inconsistencies. AI gets confused by them and skips you.

Citation by other authority sources matters more for AEO. Backlinks help Google ranking. Being mentioned (even without a link) helps AEO.

The honest conclusion

You need both. Anyone telling you otherwise is selling a course.

Smart operators are running them in parallel right now. SEO captures the traffic that still exists on traditional search. AEO captures the traffic that's moved to AI. The brands winning over the next three years will be the ones doing both.

This playbook is about the AEO half. Assume you're keeping the SEO half running underneath.

Chapter 4: The opportunity window

Here's why this matters right now, and not in two years.

What happened with SEO in 2005-2010

If you talk to any SEO consultant who's been in the game 15+ years, they'll tell you the same story. The brands that figured out search engine optimization between 2005 and 2010 still dominate their categories today.

Wirecutter. NerdWallet. Healthline. The Spruce. Investopedia. These weren't established media brands before SEO. They became dominant *because* of SEO, during a window when most businesses didn't take Google seriously yet.

By 2012, SEO was a known discipline. By 2015, every agency offered it. By 2020, ranking on Google for any commercial keyword required a real budget, a real team, and years of work.

The window closed.

Where AEO is right now

AEO in 2026 is roughly where SEO was in 2007.

Most businesses don't know it exists. Most agencies don't sell it. Most operators are still focused on Google rankings and Meta ads, which is fine but incomplete. The handful of brands that are actively optimizing for AI citation are quietly building positions that will be very hard to displace later.

The same compounding logic applies. Every time you get cited in an AI answer today, that citation reinforces the AI's model of who matters in your category. Each mention builds on the last. Brands that start early benefit disproportionately from this compounding.

The brands that figure this out in 2026 and 2027 will be the default AI answers in their categories for years.

Why the window is open

Three reasons most businesses haven't moved on this yet.

One, awareness. Most operators haven't connected the dots between "customers are using ChatGPT" and "my business needs to be in those answers." They notice the behavior shift but don't act on it.

Two, confusion. The few who have noticed don't know what to do. The information out there is mostly recycled SEO advice or vague theory. There's no clear playbook (which is the gap this book fills).

Three, slow feedback. AEO results take 60-90 days to show up. Most operators are wired for faster feedback loops (paid ads, social posts, email campaigns). The patience required filters out most competitors before they start.

These three barriers won't last. Awareness will spread. Information will improve. Patient operators will figure it out. Within 18-24 months, AEO will be a standard offering at every digital marketing agency, and the cost of entry will be five to ten times higher than it is today.

Right now, it isn't.

What to do with this

Don't panic. But don't wait either.

The 90-day plan in Part 4 is built specifically so you can start moving this week without quitting your other work or hiring anyone. Most of the levers in Part 3 can be executed by one person, part-time, with no tools beyond what you already have.

The cost of starting now is small. The cost of starting in 2028 will be much larger.

Let's go run your audit.

PART 2: AUDIT YOUR OWN BUSINESS

Chapter 5: The 30-prompt framework

Before you can fix anything, you need to know where you stand.

The audit answers one question. When customers ask AI about your category, how often does your business come up?

You'll run 30 prompts across 4 engines. That's 120 data points. Enough to spot patterns, not so many you burn out.

The 30 prompts split into three categories.

Category prompts (10). Broad discovery queries. "Best CRM for small business." "Best running shoes for marathons." "Best marketing agencies for SaaS." These are hard to win and have lots of competitors. They tell you whether you exist at all in the AI's category map.

Comparison prompts (10). Head-to-head queries. "[Your brand] vs [Competitor]." "Best alternative to [Competitor]." "[Brand X] vs [Brand Y] for [use case]." These are high-intent and the easiest category to move. AI loves comparison content.

Problem-solution prompts (10). Customer-pain queries. "What should I use for [problem]." "How do I [achieve outcome]." "Best tool for [specific situation]." This is where customers ask AI before they know which brands exist. Win here and you create demand instead of competing for it.

How to write good prompts: think about what your customer would actually type, not what a marketer would write. No keyword-stuffing. Full sentences. Real questions.

If you're stuck, ask three recent customers what they searched for before finding you. Use their exact words.

Chapter 6: Running the audit

Open the four engines in separate tabs.

ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity, Google (for AI Overviews, just search normally).

Work one engine at a time, not one prompt at a time. Run all 30 prompts in ChatGPT first. Log results. Move to Claude. Repeat. This saves you hours.

For each prompt in each engine, run it 2-3 times. AI answers vary between runs. You want the pattern, not a single snapshot.

Record four things per prompt:

- 1. Mention.** Yes or no. Did your business name appear in the answer?
- 2. Position.** If mentioned, were you named first, second, third, or buried later? First mention compounds the most.
- 3. Competitors named.** List every other brand that showed up. This is your map of who's winning your category.
- 4. Sources cited.** If the engine shows citations (Perplexity always does, Google AI Overviews usually does, ChatGPT and Claude sometimes do), note which sites they pulled from. This tells you exactly where the AI is looking.

Don't analyze yet. Just log. Analysis comes in Chapter 8.

Time estimate: about 2 hours per engine if you stay focused. 8 hours total. Split across two or three sittings.

Chapter 7: The audit spreadsheet

Doing this in a notebook will kill you by prompt 12. Use the spreadsheet template included with this playbook.

"See the .xlsx file in your download"

To use it: open the file in Excel, or import it into Google Sheets (File > Import > upload the .xlsx).

Save it to your own Drive or computer. Now it's yours to edit.

The template has seven tabs.

Tab 1: Start Here. Brief instructions and key concepts. Read this first.

Tab 2: Setup. Enter your business name, website, category, top 5 competitors, and the audit date. Everything else in the spreadsheet pulls from these fields, so don't skip this step.

Tab 3: Prompts. Your 30 prompts, pre-categorized and color-coded. Replace the placeholder prompts with your own. The categories (Category, Comparison, Problem-Solution) are already assigned.

Tab 4: Results. 120 rows, one per prompt-engine combination, already populated for you. Fill in four fields per row: Mentioned (Y/N), Position (0-10), Competitors Named, Sources Cited. The Mentioned column turns green for Y and red for N as you go, so you can see your progress visually.

Tab 5: Share of Voice. Auto-calculates from Tab 4. Shows your total share of voice, broken down by engine, by category, and by engine x category cross-tab. No formulas to touch. It updates as you log.

Tab 6: Competitor Map. Auto-tallies every competitor named in Tab 4. Ranks them by share of voice. Compares them directly against your own share. This is the map of who's eating your category.

Tab 7: Action Plan. Pre-structured by the seven levers from Part 3. Three action slots per lever. Fill this in after you finish the audit and read Part 3.

Set a timer for 25 minutes. Run prompts, log results, move on. Don't perfect. Don't analyze. Just fill the sheet.

Analysis comes in the next chapter.

A Note on Automation

A question you're probably asking right now: can't AI just do this audit for me?

Yes, it can. And there are tools that already do it.

Profound (profound.so), Otterly (otterly.ai), Peec AI (peec.ai), and AthenaHQ (athenahq.ai) all track brand visibility across AI engines automatically.

They run prompts on a schedule, dashboard the results, and alert you when share of voice changes. Pricing ranges from \$50 to \$500 per month.

So why are you about to spend 90 minutes running an audit manually?

Two reasons.

One. Manual builds intuition. Automation gives data.

When you run the audit yourself, you read the actual AI responses. You see which competitors get named first. You click into the cited sources and find the patterns. You develop a gut sense for *why* certain brands win and others don't.

Automated tools skip this entirely. They give you a dashboard showing your share of voice is 14%. They don't tell you that 9 of the 10 prompts where you lost cited the same three Reddit threads, which is where you should focus your energy.

The intuition matters more than the data. The data without the intuition is just a number on a screen.

Two. The methodology is the same either way.

Whether you audit manually or use a tool, the seven levers in Part 3 don't change. The 90-day plan doesn't change. The outreach templates don't change. Automation only saves you the time of running prompts and logging results. It doesn't replace the strategy or the execution.

Here's what I actually recommend.

Run your first audit manually using the spreadsheet. Spend the 90 minutes. Build the intuition. You'll see things in the cited sources that no dashboard would have shown you.

After the first audit, switch to automation for ongoing tracking. Pick one of the tools listed above based on budget. Use them to monitor share of voice over time. Spend your saved hours executing the levers, not running prompts.

The combination is the real answer.

Two things coming soon.

If you'd rather skip the manual work entirely and have me run an audit on your business, that's available as a separate service. Cost is \$397 for a one-time audit with a strategy walkthrough. Email **aeoplaybook@protonmail.com** if interested. *(Why do I use Proton Mail, you might ask? It's encrypted and secure. It's a thing, trust me. When you give access of your whole life to AI agents, you've got to do whatever you can to have just a teeny tiny bit of privacy.)*

I'm also building a lightweight automated audit tool specifically for buyers of this playbook. Faster than manual, less expensive than continuous-monitoring SaaS tools, output format matched to the spreadsheet you already know how to read. If you want early access when it launches, email **aeoplaybook@protonmail.com** with "audit tool waitlist" in the subject.

Chapter 8: Reading your results

You've filled the sheet. Now interpret it.

There are four questions to ask, in order.

1. What's your headline number?

Look at the Share of Voice tab. The big percentage at the top.

Under 10% means you're effectively invisible. Most new businesses are here. Don't panic. The 90-day plan in Part 4 is designed for businesses starting from zero.

10 to 30% means you have a foothold. Some signals are working. The audit will show you which.

Above 30% means you're already doing something right and the playbook will help you compound it.

Your absolute number matters less than your direction over time. Re-running the audit in 90 days is how you measure progress.

2. Where are you strongest and weakest?

Look at the Share of Voice by Category breakdown.

If you're strongest in Comparison prompts, it means your brand is known enough to be put against competitors, but maybe not strong enough to appear in broad discovery. Lever 3 (comparison content) and Lever 1 (authority sites) are your biggest opportunities.

If you're strongest in Problem-Solution prompts, your content is doing some heavy lifting, but you're not in the AI's brand map for your category. Lever 6 (entity clarity) and Lever 1 (authority sites) matter most.

If you're strongest in Category prompts, you have brand authority but might be losing on specific use cases. Lever 4 (FAQ content) and Lever 3 (comparison content) close the gap.

If you're invisible in all three, you're starting from zero. That's fine. Part 4 has a 90-day plan for exactly this scenario.

3. Which engine is winning you and which is ignoring you?

Look at the Share of Voice by Engine breakdown.

Engines weight signals differently. If Perplexity is citing you but ChatGPT isn't, you have web presence but weak training-data presence. The fix is more authority site coverage and more press.

If Google AI Overviews is citing you but Perplexity isn't, you have good SEO foundations but weak Reddit and forum presence. Lever 2 (Reddit) is your priority.

If you're missing from all four, you're starting from scratch. The plan handles this.

4. Who's winning and why?

Look at the Competitor Map tab. The competitor with the highest share of voice is your benchmark.

Click into the sources cited for the prompts they're winning. Look for patterns. Are they on Wirecutter? Are they in three different "best of" articles? Are they all over Reddit? Are they on a specific YouTube channel?

That pattern is your roadmap. The reason they're cited is the thing you need to build.

Spend 30 minutes on this. The diagnosis is more valuable than the data.

PART 3: THE 7 LEVERS THAT GET YOU CITED

Lever 1: Third-Party Authority Sites

This is the single biggest lever. If you only execute one thing in this playbook, do this.

What it is

Getting your business mentioned on websites the AI already trusts. Roundup articles, review sites, industry publications, niche blogs. The "best of" lists, the comparison roundups, the listicles that show up when someone searches your category on Google.

Why it works

AI engines weight third-party validation more than anything else. When ChatGPT decides which CRM tools to recommend, it doesn't trust any one CRM company's website. It trusts what independent sources say. So when Wirecutter, Forbes, TechCrunch, a popular industry blogger, or a niche review site says your business is good, that signal compounds across every AI engine simultaneously.

One mention on the right site can move your share of voice more than a month of work elsewhere.

The four types of authority sites that matter

1. Roundups and "best of" lists. Articles titled "Best [your category] in 2026" or "Top 10 [your category] for [use case]." These are the highest-value targets because they're written to be referenced.

2. Comparison and review sites. Niche sites that review products or services in your category. Examples: G2 and Capterra for SaaS, Wirecutter and The Spruce for consumer products, Clutch for agencies.

3. Industry publications. Trade magazines, vertical news sites, and respected newsletters in your space. Smaller than mainstream press but trusted within the niche.

4. Personal blogs and Substacks. Individual experts who write about your category. Often overlooked. Often easier to pitch than big publications. AI engines pull from them readily.

How to find them

Open Google. Search for the prompts where your competitor beat you in the audit. Look at the top 10 results. Those are the sites AI is pulling from.

Make a list of every site that appears more than once. That's your target list. Prioritize by domain authority (use a free Moz or Ahrefs check) but don't ignore smaller niche sites. A mention on a focused industry blog can sometimes outperform a mention on a bigger but less-relevant site.

Aim for a target list of 30 to 50 sites.

The outreach playbook

You pitch each site individually. No mass emails. AI rewards quality, not volume.

For each site, find the writer or editor who covers your category. Look at their recent articles. Send a personalized email. Three versions to try:

Version A: The product offer (for product businesses)

"Hi [name], I read your piece on [their recent article] and noticed you cover [category]. I run [your business], a [one-sentence description]. Happy to send you a free unit to test if you're working on anything in this space. No expectation of coverage, just want it in your hands."

Version B: The expert source (for service businesses)

"Hi [name], I saw your piece on [their recent article]. I run [your business] and we've worked with [number] of [target customer] on exactly this problem. If you're ever working on something in this space and need a quick expert quote or data point, I'm happy to provide it. No catch."

Version C: The data hook

"Hi [name], I ran an analysis of [specific finding from your work] across [number] of [your category]. The results were [interesting hook]. If it's useful for anything you're writing, happy to send it over with full data."

Send 5 to 10 of these per week. Track responses. Follow up once after seven days. Don't follow up more than once. Move on.

Realistic expectations

Most pitches will not get a reply. That's fine. You're playing the volume game.

Reply rate: 5 to 15% if your pitch is decent. Coverage rate: 1 to 5% of replies turn into actual mentions.

Out of 100 pitches, expect two to five real mentions over a 90-day period. That's enough to meaningfully move share of voice if the sites are well-chosen.

Template: Cold pitch email (full version)

Subject: Quick offer re: your [category] coverage

Hi [first name],

I read your recent piece on [specific article title] and appreciated [specific thing you actually liked, one sentence].

Quick context on me: I run [business name], a [one-sentence description of what you do and who it's for]. We [one specific proof point: years in business, customers served, traction metric].

I'm not pitching coverage. But two things you might find useful:

1. [Specific offer relevant to their work, e.g., free product, expert quote, data, customer interview]
2. [Second offer, optional]

If either is interesting, just reply and I'll send it over.

If not, no worries, I'll stay subscribed to your work.

[Your name]

[Your business URL]

This template works because it leads with their work, offers value without asking for anything, and gives them an easy way to say yes or pass.

Lever 2: Reddit and Forums

AI engines pull heavily from Reddit. If your category has an active subreddit and you're not in it, you're invisible to half the AI's mental model.

Why Reddit matters more than people think

Perplexity cites Reddit constantly. ChatGPT pulls from Reddit threads in training data. Google AI Overviews now explicitly surfaces Reddit answers at the top of results. The reason is simple: Reddit is one of the few places online where real users discuss real experiences with brands, unfiltered. AI engines treat that as the closest thing to ground truth.

The 90/10 rule

Reddit will ban your account if you self-promote. The rule that works: 90% of your contributions add value with no mention of your business, 10% mention it only when directly relevant.

This is not a hack. It's the actual rule of being a useful member of a community. If you follow it, you build karma, reputation, and brand mentions naturally. If you violate it, you get banned, downvoted, and damage your brand.

Finding the right subreddits

Three places to find them:

- 1. The audit.** When you ran the audit, some prompts cited Reddit URLs. Click them. Those subreddits are the ones AI is already watching.
- 2. Search Reddit directly.** Type your category into Reddit's search bar. Look at the largest active subreddits with recent posts.
- 3. Look at your competitors.** Search "[competitor name]" on Reddit. The threads that come up tell you where your customers are discussing your space.

Aim for 3 to 5 relevant subreddits. Don't try to cover all of them.

What to actually do

Weeks 1-2: Just read. Lurk. Learn the tone, the rules, the in-jokes, what gets upvoted, what gets killed. Subscribe and observe.

Weeks 3-4: Comment helpfully on other people's threads. Answer questions in your area of expertise. Don't mention your business yet. Build karma and reputation.

Week 5+: Start posting your own threads. Useful content first (a guide, a teardown, an insight). Mention your business only when someone asks "what brand should I use" or "where can I find this" in a thread.

What kills Reddit visibility

- Posting links to your site in your first week
- Using brand-new accounts (Reddit downweights accounts under 30 days old)
- Copy-pasting the same message across multiple subreddits
- Pretending to be a customer when you're the founder (extremely punished if discovered)
- Asking friends to upvote your posts (Reddit detects this)

What works

- Posting under your real name as the founder, transparently
- Answering specific questions with specific, useful answers
- Sharing what you've learned ("here's what I figured out building this")
- Letting other people mention your brand for you, which they will if you've been helpful

Realistic expectations

Reddit is slow. You're building reputation, not running ads. Expect 60 to 90 days before you see meaningful mentions. The payoff is durable: a positively-discussed brand on Reddit gets cited by AI for years.

Template: Founder introduction post

When you're ready to introduce yourself (around week 5-6, after you've built karma):

Title: I'm the founder of [business]. Here's what I learned building it. AMA if useful.

Hi r/[subreddit]. Long-time lurker. I run [business], a [one-sentence description]. We've been at it for [time period] and helped [number] of [target customer].

I'm not here to pitch. I posted this because I've seen a few threads recently about [topic] and figured it might be useful to share what I've learned.

[2-3 specific insights from your work, written as if to a friend, not a customer. Be honest about what's hard, what surprised you, what you got wrong early on.]

Happy to answer questions if anyone's working on something similar or considering this space.

This works because it leads with value, is transparent about who you are, and gives the community a reason to engage with you specifically.

Lever 3: Comparison Content

When someone asks AI "Brand X vs Brand Y," it often cites pages literally titled that. Most businesses don't make comparison pages because it feels awkward to acknowledge competitors. That's the opportunity.

Why this works

AI loves comparison content. It's structured, it's direct, and it answers a specific high-intent question. Comparison pages also signal confidence: a brand willing to compare itself transparently reads as more trustworthy than one that pretends competitors don't exist.

High-intent searches are where buyers convert. Someone asking "Asana vs Monday" is closer to buying than someone asking "best project management tool." Comparison content captures the bottom of the funnel.

Which comparisons to write

Use your audit to decide. Your Competitor Map shows the top 5 to 10 brands eating your share of voice. Write comparison pages against each one.

Three formats:

- 1. Direct head-to-head.** "[Your Brand] vs [Competitor]." The simplest. Build one per major competitor.
- 2. Use-case comparison.** "[Your Brand] vs [Competitor] for [specific use case]." Lets you win on a narrower battleground where you're stronger.
- 3. Alternative roundups.** "Best alternatives to [market leader]." You position yourself inside a list of options, alongside the brand customers were already searching for.

Aim for 5 to 10 comparison pages in your first 90 days.

How to structure a comparison page

AI cites comparison pages that read like honest analysis, not marketing. Structure:

- 1. Quick verdict at the top.** One paragraph. Who is each brand best for. Don't bury this. AI engines pull the summary as the cited answer.
- 2. Feature-by-feature table.** Side by side. Include pricing, key features, integrations, support, target customer. Be specific.

3. **Where each brand wins.** A section for each brand. Be honest. Acknowledge specific things the competitor does better. This is counterintuitive but critical, see below.
4. **Use case recommendations.** "Choose [Brand A] if you... Choose [Brand B] if you..."
5. **FAQ at the bottom.** 4 to 6 common questions about both brands.

Why being honest about competitors works

Two reasons.

One, AI distrusts marketing copy. Pages that read like an ad get filtered. Pages that read like a neutral comparison get cited.

Two, honesty converts better than spin. A reader who finds your page when comparing options can tell the difference between honest analysis and biased fluff. Honest analysis builds trust. Trust converts.

You're not trying to win every comparison. You're trying to be the source AI cites when the comparison comes up. If the customer is genuinely better served by the competitor for their specific use case, saying so makes you more credible the next time.

What to avoid

- Generic comparisons that don't take a position
- Tables with vague checkmarks ("yes, yes, yes" on every row)
- Hiding pricing or making it hard to find
- Bashing the competitor unfairly
- Writing the page once and never updating it (re-audit every 6 months)

Realistic expectations

Comparison pages are slow to rank but fast to be cited. Once indexed, they get pulled into AI answers within weeks. Each page covers one search intent permanently. Five well-written comparison pages can compound for years.

Template: Comparison page outline

Title: [Your Brand] vs [Competitor]: Honest Comparison (2026)

H1: [Your Brand] vs [Competitor]

Section 1: Quick verdict (1 paragraph)

"Both brands serve [target market]. [Your Brand] is best for

[specific use case]. [Competitor] is best for [specific different use case]."

Section 2: Side-by-side comparison table

Columns: Feature, [Your Brand], [Competitor]

Rows: Pricing, [feature 1], [feature 2], [feature 3], support, integrations, target customer.

Section 3: Where [Your Brand] wins

3-5 specific points with brief explanations.

Section 4: Where [Competitor] wins

3-5 specific points. Be honest.

Section 5: Choose [Your Brand] if...

Bullet list, 3-5 items.

Section 6: Choose [Competitor] if...

Bullet list, 3-5 items.

Section 7: FAQ

4-6 common questions about both brands.

Use this for every comparison page. Same structure, different content. The consistency is what makes AI parse it reliably.

Lever 4: FAQ and Answer Content

AI engines are built to answer questions. So they prefer content that already looks like an answer. If your site has pages structured as direct question-and-answer pairs, you get cited more often than competitors hiding the same information inside long-form prose.

Why this works

When ChatGPT or Perplexity processes a page, the easiest content to extract and cite is content already in question-answer format. A page with the H2 "What is the best running shoe for marathon training?" followed by a clear three-sentence answer is dramatically easier for AI to pull from than a 2000-word blog post that buries the answer in paragraph nine.

You're doing the work of structuring the answer so the AI doesn't have to.

What questions to answer

Three sources:

- 1. Your audit.** Problem-Solution prompts where you didn't appear. Those are direct questions your customers ask AI. Build a page that answers each one.
- 2. "People also ask" boxes.** Google any prompt in your category and look at the "People Also Ask" section. Those are the related questions Google has identified. Build a page for each.
- 3. Your customers.** Email three recent customers. Ask: "What did you search for before you found us?" Use their exact words.

Aim for 10 to 20 FAQ-style pages in your first 90 days.

Where to put them

Two options. Both work. Pick based on your business.

Dedicated FAQ pages. A single page per question. Title: "How do I [specific task]?" Body: 300 to 800 words. Answer the question directly in the first paragraph, then expand. This works best for high-intent questions where you want to rank for the exact query.

FAQ sections on existing pages. Add 4 to 8 questions at the bottom of product pages, service pages, and comparison pages. Same format. Question as a header, direct answer below. This is the lower-effort path that still moves the needle.

I recommend both. Build dedicated pages for your top 10 highest-intent questions. Add FAQ sections to every other key page on your site.

How to format the answer

Three rules:

1. Answer in the first 50 words. Don't make AI hunt. The first sentence should directly answer the question.

2. Use plain language. Write like you're explaining to a customer, not impressing a colleague. AI prefers clarity over jargon.

3. Add structure. Lists, sub-headers, and short paragraphs. Pages that look like answers get pulled as answers.

What to avoid

- Walls of text without headers
- Burying the answer in the middle of a long article
- "It depends" non-answers (AI skips these)
- SEO-stuffing with keywords ("best best running shoes shoes for marathon marathon")
- Making the user click to expand to see the answer (AI doesn't click)

Realistic expectations

FAQ content gets indexed fast and cited fast. You can see results in 4 to 6 weeks. Each page targets a narrow question, but the cumulative effect is large. Twenty well-written FAQ pages can drive a meaningful share-of-voice lift on their own.

Template: FAQ page structure

Title: [The exact question, as a customer would ask it]

H1: [The exact question]

Direct answer (first paragraph, 40-60 words):

"The short answer is [direct response]. [One sentence of context]. [One sentence on when this applies or doesn't]."

Section 1: [Sub-question 1]

2-3 paragraphs. Specific. Actionable.

Section 2: [Sub-question 2]

2-3 paragraphs.

Section 3: [Sub-question 3]

2-3 paragraphs.

Bottom: Related questions

3-5 links to other FAQ pages on your site.

Add FAQ schema markup (covered in Lever 5) to make these pages machine-readable. That combination, structured content plus structured data, is what gets pulled into AI answers most reliably.

A note on the May 2026 schema change. As of May 7, 2026, Google no longer displays FAQ rich results in search (the expandable dropdowns under listings). This does not affect the strategy in this section. AI engines still pull from clearly structured question-and-answer content. The shift is that FAQ markup is no longer a Google SERP hack. It remains a valuable structural signal for AI retrieval, which is exactly what we care about here. The content strategy stays the same. The schema implementation changes slightly, covered in the next lever.

Lever 5: Schema Markup

Schema markup is structured data you add to your website's code. It tells AI engines exactly what your page is about, in a format machines can parse instantly.

As of 2026, schema is no longer primarily a Google SERP tool. It's an AI retrieval signal. The brands that get this right get cited more often. The brands that follow outdated advice waste effort.

What changed in May 2026

Google deprecated FAQ rich results on May 7, 2026. The expandable Q&A dropdowns under search listings are gone. A lot of cheap AEO content still tells you to focus on FAQ schema for SERP visibility. That advice is dead.

What's true: FAQ schema is no longer a Google SERP lever. What's also true: schema in general matters more for AI citation than ever. Two separate things, and most people are conflating them.

The four schema types that move the needle now

1. Organization schema. Defines what your business is. Name, description, logo, founding date, key people. This is the single highest-value schema for AI citation because it builds entity clarity. AI engines use it to understand who you are.

2. Product schema. For product businesses. Defines each product, its price, availability, reviews. AI pulls product info from this directly when answering "best X" queries.

3. Article schema. For blog posts and editorial content. Defines author, publish date, topic. Signals freshness and authority.

4. HowTo schema. For step-by-step instructional content. AI engines love this for problem-solution queries.

FAQ schema can stay on your pages if it's already there. It doesn't hurt. It just isn't a priority anymore.

How to implement

You don't need to write schema by hand. Three paths depending on your platform.

Shopify: Most themes include basic Product and Organization schema by default. Use an app like Smart SEO or JSON-LD for SEO to add more. 10 minutes of setup.

WordPress: Install Rank Math or Yoast SEO. Both add Organization, Article, and Product schema automatically. 15 minutes of setup.

Custom site: Generate the JSON-LD code at schema.org or use Google's structured data tool. Paste it into the head of your page. Each schema type takes 20-30 minutes.

How to validate

Use Schema.org's validator (validator.schema.org). It tells you if your markup is correct. Run every important page through it.

Note: Google retired its Rich Results Test for FAQ in June 2026, but the Schema.org validator still works for all schema types.

What to avoid

- Adding schema to pages where the visible content doesn't match (this gets flagged as spam)
- Stuffing irrelevant schema types in hopes of "more signals"
- Copy-pasting schema from another site without changing the values
- Treating schema as a replacement for good content. It amplifies what's already there. It doesn't create something that isn't.

Realistic expectations

Schema is foundational, not flashy. You won't see immediate share-of-voice lift from adding it. But every other lever in this playbook works better when your schema is clean. Think of it as the structural plumbing that makes the rest of the work cite-able.

A full schema sweep (Organization, Product, Article on every key page) takes a half day to a full day. Do it once. Maintain quarterly.

Lever 6: Entity Clarity

If AI doesn't know exactly what your business is, it won't cite you. Entity clarity is the work of making your business definition consistent and machine-readable everywhere it appears online.

Why this matters

AI engines build an internal map of every business they've encountered. The map includes what you sell, who you serve, where you're based, and how you differ from competitors. If that map is fuzzy or contradictory, the AI plays it safe and skips you in favor of a competitor whose definition is clear.

Inconsistency kills citation. A brand described three different ways across the web gets cited less than a brand described one way everywhere.

The 5 places your definition must match

Walk through each of these and make sure the description of your business is identical (or nearly identical) across all five.

- 1. Your website.** The About page, the homepage hero, and the meta description should all describe your business the same way. One sentence. Specific. Memorable.
- 2. LinkedIn.** Company page tagline and "About" section.
- 3. Crunchbase.** Even if you're not a startup, claim your profile. It's free and AI pulls from it.
- 4. Social bios.** X, Instagram, TikTok, wherever you exist. Same description.
- 5. Wikipedia.** If you have a page. If not, see below.

The 1-hour brand entity audit

Set aside one hour. Open all five sources in tabs. Read each description out loud. Note every inconsistency.

Common issues:

- Your website says "men's running apparel" but LinkedIn says "athletic clothing brand"
- Your X bio says "premium" but your About page says "affordable"
- Your Crunchbase says you're based in Los Angeles but your website says Brooklyn
- One source mentions a product line you've since discontinued

Fix every inconsistency. Pick the single best description and propagate it everywhere.

About Wikipedia

Wikipedia is the most cited source in AI training data. A page there is gold.

Most small businesses don't qualify. Wikipedia requires "notability," which usually means multiple independent press mentions in established publications.

Don't try to game this. Wikipedia editors detect self-promotion fast and will block you. Instead, do the work in Lever 1 (authority sites) until you naturally accumulate press, then a Wikipedia page becomes possible. Some brands hire editors to handle the submission once they qualify, which costs \$500 to \$2,000 and is worth it if you're eligible.

What to avoid

- Letting different team members write different bios independently
- Vague descriptions that could apply to any business in your category
- Changing your description every few months as you pivot
- Pretending to be bigger or older than you are (AI cross-checks)

Realistic expectations

Entity clarity is invisible work. You won't see a graph go up. But every other lever works better when your entity definition is clean. It's the difference between AI saying "there's a company called [your brand]" and AI saying "[your brand] is the [specific category] brand for [specific customer]."

A clean entity definition compounds across every prompt, every engine, every quarter. Do this once, maintain it forever.

Lever 7: Owned Presence on AI-Crawled Platforms

Your website isn't the only place AI looks. Several third-party platforms get crawled heavily by AI engines, and posting there extends your citation footprint with relatively little effort.

The platforms that matter

LinkedIn. Posts and articles get indexed and pulled into AI answers, especially for B2B queries. Founder-written posts perform better than company-page posts.

Medium. Older platform, still heavily crawled. Articles published here compound for years.

Substack. Newer, growing fast in AI citations. Newsletters with consistent publishing get pulled into AI answers as authority signals.

YouTube. Video transcripts get indexed. AI engines parse transcripts and cite the underlying content. Even a small channel with good transcripts can be cited.

Podcasts. Episode transcripts get crawled if they're published as text on the show's website. Being a guest on a podcast with strong distribution can place you in AI answers within weeks.

The hub-and-spoke strategy

Your website is the hub. These platforms are the spokes.

Every piece of meaningful content you write should be repurposed across at least two spoke platforms. A founder essay on your blog gets reposted as a LinkedIn article. A product launch announcement becomes a Medium post. A teardown becomes a YouTube video with a full transcript.

This isn't about volume. It's about presence. The same idea, in your voice, in multiple places AI is looking.

What to post

Three content types work best:

1. Teardowns. Your analysis of something specific in your space. A competitor's strategy, a recent industry shift, a tool you tested. AI engines pull from analytical content readily.

2. Lessons learned. Founder-voice writing about what you figured out building your business. The "here's what I learned" format performs across every platform.

3. Data and original research. If you ran a survey, audited a category, or have data nobody else has, publish it. Original data gets cited disproportionately.

Skip generic listicles. AI is saturated with those and will rarely cite them.

Realistic cadence

You don't need to post daily. Consistency over volume.

- LinkedIn: 1-2 posts per week
- Medium or Substack: 1 article every 2-3 weeks
- YouTube: 1-2 videos per month with transcripts
- Podcast guesting: 1-2 appearances per quarter

A founder posting at this rate, consistently, for 6 months, will see meaningful AI citation lift.

What to avoid

- Cross-posting identical content with no adaptation (each platform has its own format)
- Auto-generated AI content (AI engines down-weight obviously AI-written posts)
- Engagement-bait posts (no value, no citation lift)
- Going silent for months between bursts

Realistic expectations

This is the lever with the longest payoff and the lowest upfront cost. A LinkedIn article you write today can still be cited in AI answers two years from now. You're building a permanent presence in the AI's information layer.

Treat it like compounding interest. Small, consistent deposits over a long horizon.

PART 4: THE 90-DAY EXECUTION PLAN

Chapter 9: Why 90 days

AEO is slow, but it's not SEO-slow.

SEO took 6 to 12 months to show meaningful results. AEO shows movement in 60 to 90 days if you execute the levers consistently. The reason is mechanical: AI engines crawl and re-index content faster than Google ranks it, and citation patterns can shift within weeks of new authority signals appearing online.

90 days is the right horizon for three reasons.

One. It's long enough for compounding signals to register. Press mentions, Reddit threads, and comparison pages need a few crawl cycles before they show up in AI answers.

Two. It's short enough to stay focused. Anything beyond 90 days and most operators drift, lose momentum, and quit.

Three. It produces a measurable result. You re-run the audit at day 90 and see whether your share of voice moved. That number tells you what to do next.

This plan is built for one person working part-time. Roughly 5 to 10 hours per week. If you have a team, it scales faster. If you're solo and busy, it still works at this pace.

Chapter 10: Days 1-30 (Foundation)

The first 30 days are about fixing what's broken and building the assets that everything else depends on.

Week 1: Audit and diagnose

- Run the full 30-prompt audit across 4 engines
- Fill in the spreadsheet
- Read your results (Share of Voice, Competitor Map)
- Identify your top 3 priority levers based on weakness

Week 2: Entity clarity sweep

- Run the 1-hour brand entity audit (Lever 6)
- Fix every inconsistency across website, LinkedIn, Crunchbase, social, Wikipedia
- Lock the single best description of your business

Week 3: Schema implementation

- Install Organization schema on your homepage
- Install Product or Service schema on key pages
- Install Article schema on your blog
- Validate everything with the Schema.org validator

Week 4: Build the first comparison pages

- Write 2-3 comparison pages targeting your top competitors (Lever 3)
- Publish them with proper structure: verdict, table, honest pros/cons, FAQ
- Submit to Google Search Console for indexing

By day 30, your foundation is set. Entity is clean, schema is live, comparison content exists. The next 60 days are amplification.

Chapter 11: Days 31-60 (Outreach)

The middle 30 days are about outreach and content. This is where you put yourself in front of the AI's information sources.

Week 5: Build your authority site target list

- Identify 30-50 sites AI is already pulling from (use your audit)
- Find the writer or editor at each
- Build a tracking spreadsheet (site, contact, date pitched, response)

Week 6: Begin outreach cadence

- Send 5-10 personalized pitches per week using the template in Lever 1
- Track every response
- Follow up once after 7 days, then move on

Week 7: Reddit engagement begins

- Identify 3-5 subreddits relevant to your business
- Lurk, learn the tone, subscribe
- Start commenting helpfully on existing threads (90/10 rule)

Week 8: Spoke content launch

- Publish your first LinkedIn article (founder voice, teardown or lesson)
- Publish your first Medium or Substack piece
- Repurpose existing content across at least one new spoke

By day 60, you've sent 30-50 outreach emails, built early reputation on Reddit, and started a content distribution rhythm.

Chapter 12: Days 61-90 (Compound and measure)

The final 30 days are about doubling down on what's working and measuring the delta.

Week 9: Continue outreach + build more comparison pages

- Keep outreach at 5-10 pitches per week
- Add 2-3 more comparison pages targeting next-tier competitors
- Build out FAQ content for your top 5 problem-solution prompts

Week 10: Deepen Reddit presence

- Post your first founder introduction on a relevant subreddit (template in Lever 2)
- Continue commenting helpfully
- Track brand mentions and discussion

Week 11: Re-run the audit

- Same 30 prompts, same 4 engines
- Fill in the spreadsheet again
- Compare day 1 share of voice to day 90 share of voice

Week 12: Adjust based on what moved

- Which levers moved the needle most? Double down.
- Which levers showed no movement? Diagnose why.
- Plan the next 90 days based on what worked.

By day 90, you have a measurable share-of-voice delta and a clear picture of which levers compound for your specific business.

Chapter 13: How to know it's working

Three signals to watch.

Share of voice delta. Your headline metric. Re-run the audit every 90 days and track the change over time. Aim for 2x to 3x lift in the first 90 days if you're starting from a low base.

New brand mentions. Set up Google Alerts for your brand name. New mentions on authority sites, Reddit threads, and AI engines mean your work is registering.

Branded search lift. Check Google Search Console. If branded searches (people typing your business name) are increasing, AI mentions are driving discovery. This is a leading indicator that the system is working.

If all three are moving up at day 90, you're on the right track. If two of three are moving, focus on the one that isn't. If none are moving, re-run the audit and diagnose which lever you neglected.

PART 5: COMMON MISTAKES

Chapter 14: What kills AEO progress

Most people who fail at AEO don't fail because the strategy is wrong. They fail because they make one of these mistakes early and never recover. Read this before you start. Read it again at week 4.

Treating AEO like SEO

The biggest one. People bring SEO habits to AEO and wonder why nothing moves.

Keyword stuffing doesn't work. AI engines don't reward density. They reward clarity and authority.

Backlink chasing matters less. A mention on a relevant authority site without a link beats a low-quality backlink. AI engines count citations, not just hyperlinks.

Technical SEO doesn't transfer cleanly. Page speed and mobile optimization still matter for Google. They don't move AI citation directly.

AEO is its own discipline. Treat it that way.

Trying to game Reddit

The fastest way to destroy your brand in AI search is to get publicly called out as spamming Reddit.

Don't use fake accounts. Don't pay for upvotes. Don't pose as a customer when you're the founder. Don't mass-post the same content across subreddits. Reddit detects all of this, and the resulting threads (titled "this brand is astroturfing") get pulled into AI answers permanently.

Reddit works only if you participate honestly. Slow and real beats fast and fake every time.

Adding schema without good content

Schema amplifies what's already on the page. It doesn't create authority that isn't there.

If your page is thin, schema won't fix it. If your content is generic, schema won't make it cite-able. Build good content first. Add schema second.

Empty schema (markup on pages with no real content behind it) can actually get you down-weighted. Don't do it.

Inconsistent entity definitions

We covered this in Lever 6, but it bears repeating because it's so common.

Different bios on different platforms. Different descriptions on different pages. A pivot you forgot to propagate across your social profiles. Each inconsistency makes AI less confident about who you are. Less confident means less cited.

Pick one description. Use it everywhere. Update it everywhere when it changes.

Expecting results in 30 days

You won't see meaningful share-of-voice movement in 30 days. You might see early signals (a new mention, a Reddit thread), but the audit number won't shift much yet.

The trap: people get discouraged at day 25, stop executing, and never see the day-60 lift that was coming.

The system compounds. Trust the 90-day window. Re-run the audit at day 90, not day 30.

Ignoring negative mentions

You can be cited badly. A Reddit thread complaining about your product. A negative review on a forum. A blog post listing you as the brand to avoid.

AI engines pull from negative sources too. If a competitor's "X is overpriced" thread is the most active discussion of your brand on Reddit, AI may cite that framing.

Monitor mentions. Respond publicly to legitimate complaints. Address recurring issues at the product level. Negative mentions handled well become neutral. Ignored, they become permanent.

Building everything alone

AEO touches content, PR, community, technical SEO, and brand. Most founders can't do all of it themselves at high quality.

You don't need a team. But you might need help with one or two pieces. A freelance PR person for outreach. A technical contractor for schema. A part-time writer for comparison content.

Don't let "I'll do it all myself" become the reason nothing ships. Better to execute three levers well than seven levers half-built.

PART 6: IF YOU'D RATHER NOT DIY

Chapter 15: When to hire it out

You've read the playbook. You know what works. Now you have a decision.

Do this yourself, or hire someone to do it for you.

There's no wrong answer. There's only the right answer for your situation. Here's the honest framework.

Do it yourself if

You have 5 to 10 hours a week to dedicate to it consistently. You enjoy the work (writing, outreach, analysis). Your business is early enough that cash flow matters more than time. You want to own the expertise long-term, not rent it.

If those four are true, the playbook in your hands is enough. Execute the 90-day plan. Re-run the audit. Iterate. Most businesses can do this themselves with discipline.

Hire it out if

You don't have 5 to 10 hours a week, consistently, for the next 90 days. You'd rather pay someone than do the work yourself. Your time is worth more elsewhere (closing deals, building product, managing your team). You want to compress 90 days of effort into 30 days of execution.

If those are closer to true, hiring this out makes sense. The math is straightforward: if your time is worth \$200 an hour and AEO takes 100 hours over 90 days, that's \$20,000 of your time. Paying someone \$3,000 to \$5,000 a month to handle it is often the cheaper option once you account for what else you could be doing.

What hiring an AEO specialist should include

If you do hire, know what you're paying for. A real AEO retainer includes:

- Monthly audit with share-of-voice tracking
- Authority site outreach (15 to 30 pitches per month)
- Reddit and forum strategy and engagement
- 2 to 4 comparison or FAQ pages per month
- Schema implementation and maintenance
- Entity clarity audits across all platforms
- Monthly reporting with measurable deltas

Anything less is overpriced. Anything more is rare and worth premium pricing.

Red flags when hiring

Avoid anyone who:

- Promises specific share-of-voice numbers in writing (the variable is too noisy for guarantees)
- Sells "AEO" as bolted-on SEO with no separate methodology
- Doesn't run an audit before pitching their service
- Can't show their own brand winning in AI search
- Refuses to explain their process in plain language

If you want me to do this for you

I run AEO consulting for businesses that have read this playbook and decided they'd rather not DIY. Same methodology, executed by me.

I'm selective about who I take on. I work best with businesses that have a real product, real customers, and real traction. If that's you, book a free 30-minute strategy call.

On the call, we'll:

- Review your audit results together
- Identify the 2 to 3 levers most likely to move your share of voice fastest
- Talk through whether a retainer makes sense for your business
- Be honest if it doesn't

No pitch deck. No pressure. Either it's a fit and we work together, or it isn't and you walk away with free strategy.

Book a call: <https://calendly.com/aeoplaybook/30min>

RESOURCES

Tools mentioned in this playbook

For running the audit

- ChatGPT (chat.openai.com)
- Claude (claude.ai)
- Perplexity (perplexity.ai)
- Google AI Overviews (just search on google.com)

For tracking AI citations at scale (optional, paid)

- Profound (profound.so)
- Otterly (otterly.ai)
- Peec AI (peec.ai)
- AthenaHQ (athenahq.ai)

These tools automate what you'd otherwise do manually. Useful once you're running audits for multiple businesses or want continuous tracking. Skip them while you're still on your first audit.

For schema markup

- Schema.org validator (validator.schema.org)
- Google Structured Data Markup Helper
- Rank Math or Yoast SEO (WordPress plugins)
- Smart SEO or JSON-LD for SEO (Shopify apps)

For tracking brand mentions

- Google Alerts (free)
- Mention.com or Brand24 (paid, more comprehensive)

For outreach

- Hunter.io (finding email addresses)
- Apollo (contact database)
- A simple Google Sheet (tracking pitches and responses)

Templates referenced in this playbook

All templates from this playbook are in the appendix at the end of this document. The full list:

- Cold pitch email template (Lever 1)
- Founder introduction post for Reddit (Lever 2)
- Comparison page outline (Lever 3)

- FAQ page structure (Lever 4)
- The 30-prompt audit framework (Part 2)
- The audit spreadsheet template (separate file, included with your purchase)

A final ask

If this playbook helped you, two things would mean a lot.

One. Reply to the email that delivered your purchase. Tell me what worked, what didn't, and what you want me to cover in the next edition. I read every response. Future versions are shaped by what readers actually need.

Two. If you know another founder or operator who's getting beat in AI search, send them the link. Word of mouth is how this playbook reaches the people who need it.

That's it. Go execute.

A note on versioning

This is The AEO Playbook, v1.0, published 2026.

Major updates (new engines, new methodology, new templates) ship as new versions. Buyers receive every version automatically.